



cover story GUJARAT ELECTIONS

he became an independent force in the party. The Digvijay Singhs and Ashok Gehlots of the Congress, for example, have been reined in with administrative jobs at the Centre, while both would rather lead the campaigns for assembly elections in Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan next year, where the party feels it has a strong chance of a comeback. So far the Congress has no leader to take on Vasundhara Raje in Rajasthan and has not decided whom to project as a leader in Madhya Pradesh.

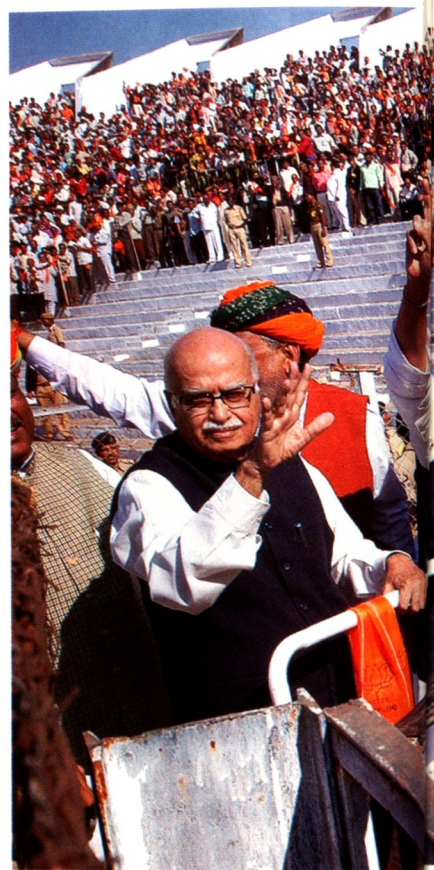
Post-Gujarat, where it has clearly failed to take on BJP on its own strength, the Congress will also have to be more accommodative of its allies. One of the Congress party's two electoral wins this year was with NCP support in Goa. It was no coincidence that Sharad Pawar visited Shiv Sena chief Bal Thackeray a few hours after the Gujarat verdict. NCP was sending a signal to the Congress not to replace Deshmukh with Narayan Rane as the Maharashtra chief minister. In Gujarat, even NCP did better than the Congress, winning three of the eight seats it contested. As a gleeful Nitish Kumar said, "Now Lalu Yadav's importance will increase as the Congress will depend more on its UPA allies." To add to its woes, BSP's Mayawati threatens to

stand to gain if Patel's authority within the party is weakened. One such veteran is Arjun Singh, leader of the old guard displaced by Patel's ascendancy. Singh was invited to the internal meet that took stock of the situation, not because he played a major role in Gujarat polls but because he needed to be discouraged from voicing his grievances outside. At the meeting he said somewhat enigmatically, "*Gujarat ko alag nazar se nahin dekhna chahiye* (we should not look at Gujarat in isolation)." The rest could do nothing but simply stare at each other, wandering how to interpret this salvo.

What requires no interpretation however is that 2007 has been a dismal year electorally for the Congress.

BJP: ON A ROLL

It was at Atal Behari Vajpayee's 84th birthday celebrations that his old friend and BJP's prime ministerial candidate Advani recalled that when four years ago, he and Bhairon Singh Shekhawat had gone to greet the then prime minister together, a photographer had asked him to stand behind the sofa where the other two were seated. The photographer then clicked a picture to match a similar one taken way back in 1953. Sentiment aside, it



GALVANISED BY MODITVA, BJP SAYS IT WILL STEP UP THE AGGRESSION AGAINST CONGRESS BY TALKING OF DEVELOPMENT AND NATIONALISM

cut into the Congress vote in the four northern states poised for polls. The loss of as many as 10 seats in Gujarat is being blamed on the BSP factor. The Congress may also have to tone down its confrontational approach against Mayawati, spearheaded by Rahul.

Then there is the crucial question of the nuclear deal. Conventional wisdom has it that a weakened Congress should not go ahead with the deal. It is in no position to face a mid-term poll just yet. Despite this, some party leaders are advocating a go-ahead. The final decision, according to a senior party strategist, will be taken in early January, along with another controversial decision, whether to replace the Maharashtra chief minister with Rane or not.

While there is no official witch hunt, there is a faction of the Congress that

was also a telling comment on a fading old order and the makings of a new troika—seated besides Advani on the dais was party chief Rajnath Singh. Even though he was not present, Modi's presence dominated the birthday festivities as he had just taken oath as chief minister.

Modi's decisive win has ensured that his appeal will not be limited to Gujarat alone. The party leadership, and Modi himself, have ruled out any plans to bring him to the Centre just yet. But most concede that it's only a matter of time. "Politics does not accept any form of stagnation. Politics evolves, personalities evolve," said General Secretary Arun Jaitley. There is no doubt that the Gujarat win has catapulted Modi ahead of the rest of the party's GenNext leadership. The

message was equally clear from Rajnath's press conference a few hours after the results poured in. He credited the victory to BJP's ideology and the development work carried out by the state unit under the leadership of Modi. The firecrackers that he lit afterwards seemed pale in comparison to the reverberations of his comments. Yet, despite the speculation outside BJP, the party itself is clear about its leadership hierarchy. "The next elections will be fought under the leadership of Advani while Modi will stay on in Gujarat from where he will give a vision to the nation as to how a state is to be run," said Rajiv Pratap Rudy, BJP spokesman. Other leaders echoed this thought. What was left unsaid, but was equally clear, is that Rajnath will continue as the party chief. Moreover, despite Modi's attempts to